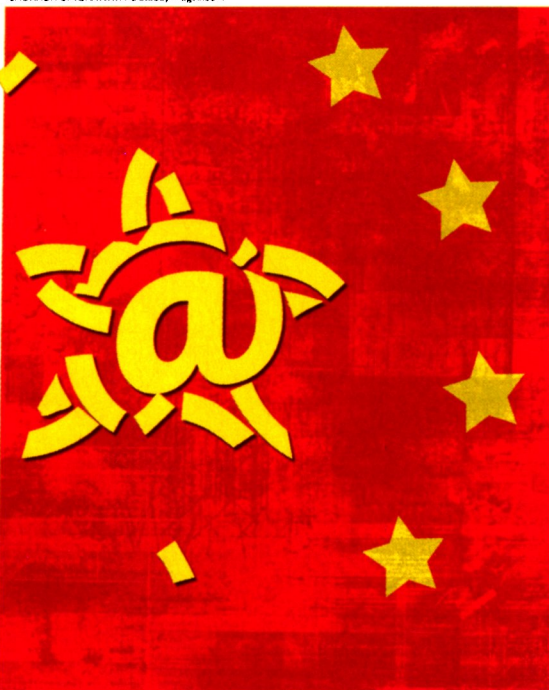


Power and Fear

In the history of unfreedom, power rhymes with fear. Maybe the power of the People's Republic can do without any more words. Hardly any topic of the post-Cold War world—whether it is extraterritorial transgressions or market domination, financial meltdown or carbon footprint—has survived without a Chinese adjective. And for us, Beijing is a complex, a comparative study, an aspiration, or a threat. Panegyrists from elsewhere continue to tell us why China is the future, or why Chinese exceptionalism is incomprehensible to the culturally insensitive outsiders. They even come out with books with titles like *When China Rules the World: The End of the Western World and the Birth of a New Global Order*. But hang on, we are talking about one of the most fragile powers on earth. China is in permanent fear, haunted by a million nameless ghosts (and not necessarily all of them as old as the Cultural Revolution). The enemy, remember, is not always the naïve foreigner, always talking about the Oriental gulag that exists in perfect harmony with Shenzhen and Shanghai. The People's Republic is scared of its own people. It wants complete control over their mind. That's why China has declared war on information, and that's why Google gagged may delete the Chinese market for the sake of freedom.

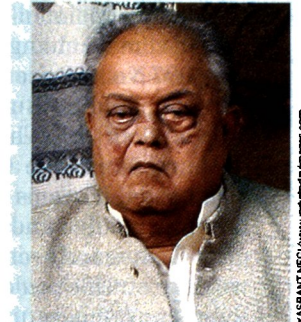
What's new? The Chinese growth story—the story of our times—has always been about the clash between marketplace and mind space. Well, there will be any number of Sinologists to tell you that it has nothing to do with communism and everything to do with Confucius. Or with what the residents of Zhongnanhai call Chinese characteristics. There are so many euphemisms to name the beast. The truth is: China lives in mortal fear of its own shadow. Mao may be confined to the souvenir shop and Big Marx may be less ubiquitous than Big Mac but the awesome Chinese project is built on a Leninist party structure which abhors questions—and knowledge. It's the oldest fear of a system that treats its people as an abstraction—the masses. It's the fear that authored Mao's Cultural Revolution, Stalin's Great Terror, and Deng's Tiananmen Square. The continuing Chinese story of free markets and fettered mind tells us that we have not come very far. It's not that China will win this war against the Internet—or information. It can't. This war of the paranoid brings out the fallibility of the power that, in the fantasy of those who celebrate the demise of the West, aspires to rule the world. Sometime in the future, a Google search will bring up the defeat of the last Big Lie through a billion results.

SAURABH SINGH | www.indiatodayimages.com



SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Samajwadi Party vice-president and former Union minister **Janeshwar Mishra**, 77. He had entered the Lok Sabha from Allahabad in 1977 on a Janata Party ticket, defeating V.P. Singh.



APPOINTED: Mrinal Pande as the chairperson of Prasar Bharati, which oversees the functioning of state-run All India Radio and Doordarshan.

BANNED: Weightlifter **Shalaja Pujari** for life. She had failed a test conducted by the National Anti-Doping Agency in September. She had won three golds at the 2002 Commonwealth Games in Manchester.

NAMED: Lt-General **Vijay Kumar Singh** as the next chief of army staff. Currently the eastern army commander, he will take over from General Deepak Kapoor on March 31



**THE CHINESE GROWTH STORY—
THE STORY OF OUR TIMES—
HAS ALWAYS BEEN ABOUT THE CLASH BETWEEN MARKETPLACE AND MIND SPACE.**

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